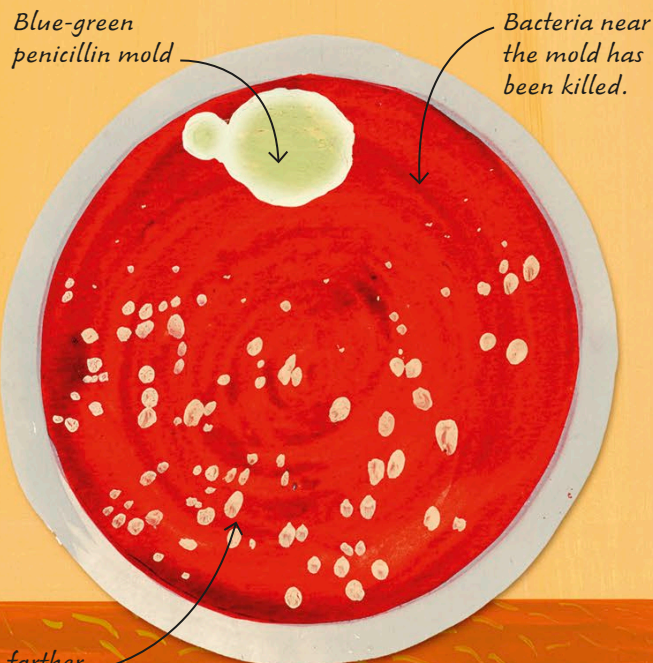


As an army doctor during World War I, Alexander Fleming saw just how deadly simple infections could be. Army hospitals treated far more soldiers for disease than for injuries caused by fighting. After the war, Alexander began hunting for something that could fight the microbes that caused these nasty infections.

At first, he focused on antiseptics, which can kill bacteria or stop them from growing. These chemicals can also harm human cells though, so they couldn't be used inside the body. Next, Alexander investigated natural substances with antibacterial effects—including his own snot! Then, one day, he stumbled upon a type of mold (fungus) that could stop bacteria in their tracks once and for all.

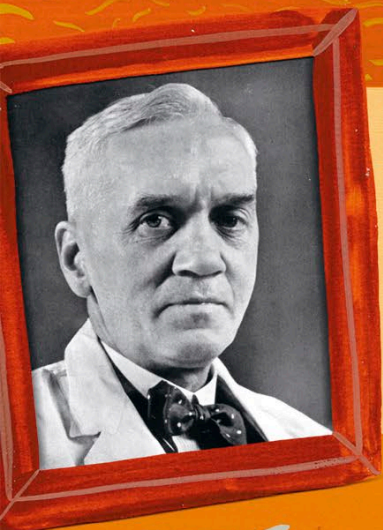
Bacteria breakthrough

Alexander decided to grow staphylococcus bacteria in Petri dishes. One day, in 1928, he noticed mold growing on an unwashed Petri dish. As he went to clean it, he noticed that the bacteria closest to the mold were dying. Could the *mold* be killing them?



Bacteria farther away is still alive.

Molds make bacteria-killing chemicals to defend themselves.



ALEXANDER FLEMING

Scottish doctor and microbiologist • 1881–1955